

Pomatomus saltatrix

Bluefish

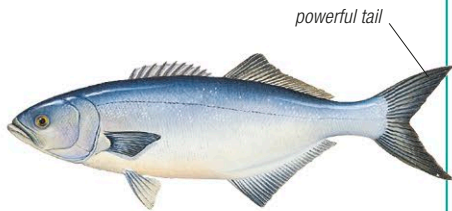


Length Up to 4 ft (1.2 m)
Weight Up to 31 lb (14 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Vulnerable

Location Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea, Indo-Pacific



The sole species in its family, this primitive, perchlike fish has an exceptionally wide distribution in coastal and estuarine waters across much of the world. Known as the tailor in Australia, it has strong jaws and rows of razor-sharp teeth, making it a powerful killing machine. Operating in packs, bluefishes attack smaller baitfishes from behind, often herding their prey into tight schools. This voracious feeder may even eat its own young. The bluefish is not territorial, and forms large schools that migrate to warmer waters to mate and spawn. The larvae and young are then carried back to cooler waters by ocean currents.



Sciaena umbra

Brown meagre

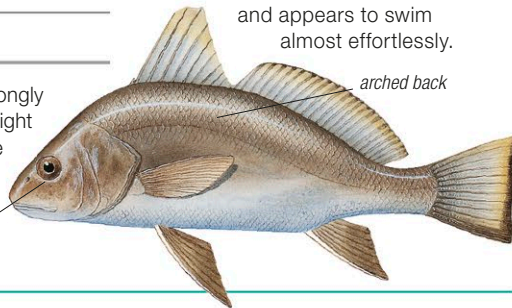


Length 28 in (70 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Near threatened

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea



A deep-bodied fish with a strongly arched back but a nearly straight underside, the brown meagre lives in inshore waters. It belongs to a large family



of 283 species. The brown meagre eats small fishes and seabed invertebrates, usually after dark. Its most notable feature is its ability to produce loud sounds, used for communication. This fish also has a sharp sense of hearing. The male brown meagre is known to use the muscles on the highly evolved swim bladder to make a drumming sound as a mating cue. This fish seems to have remarkable buoyancy control and appears to swim almost effortlessly.

Mullus surmuletus

Surmullet

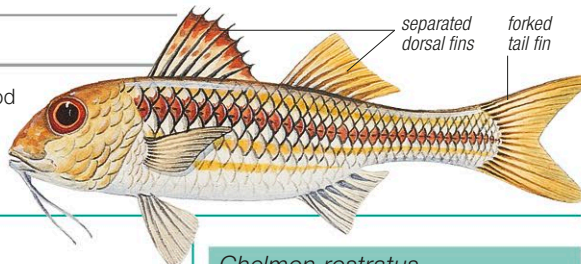


Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Up to 2¼ lb (1 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Black Sea



Highly prized as a food fish, the surmullet is reddish in color, and has a darker



red stripe along its midline, with several yellowish stripes on its lower flanks. It has a downward-pointing mouth and a pair of barbels under the chin, equipped with sensory organs that help it find food. These barbels, which give the fish its other name—the goatfish—are independently movable. They are thrust into sand and mud to detect small, seabed animals—crustaceans, worms, mollusks, and fishes.

Toxotes chatareus

Spotted archerfish

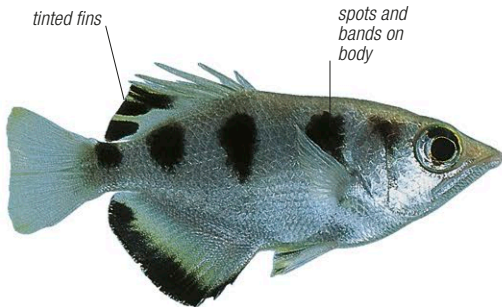


Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Up to ¼ lb (21 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location S.E. Asia, N. Australia



Found in brackish water as well as in freshwater streams and lakes, this deep-bellied, silver and black fish is famous for its ability to “shoot” insect prey off overhanging vegetation, using a precisely aimed jet of water of up to 5 ft (1.5 m). It does this by pressing its tongue against the palate, then rapidly constricting its gill chamber. Recently, it has been shown that archerfish squirt jets of water when hunting submerged prey, such as invertebrates hidden beneath silt. Juvenile archerfish need to practise their aim. This fish breeds during the wet season, releasing many thousands of buoyant eggs.



Pomacanthus imperator

Emperor angelfish



Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Sequential hermaphrodite
Status Least concern

Location Indian Ocean, Pacific



Angelfishes are among the most flamboyant inhabitants of coral reefs, with intense colors and bold patterns that often differ markedly in juveniles and adults. By appearing completely different, juveniles may avoid being chased by highly territorial adults. The emperor angelfish is a typical species, with a deep body flattened from side to side, a small mouth with comblike teeth, and a backward-pointing spine on each cheek. Like other angelfishes, it has the ability, rare among fishes, to digest the tough flesh of sponges, which are plentiful on coral reefs. This fish sometimes produces a loud thumping sound when alarmed. Though often seen on their own, males maintain a small harem of females.

JUVENILES

Young angelfishes have a strikingly different color pattern; they are dark blue to black with many concentric, curved to semicurved white lines on their sides.



STRIPES AND MARKINGS

Adults have alternating, yellow and purple oblique stripes on the body. On the head and around the pectoral fin are light blue, dark blue, and black markings.



Chelmon rostratus

Copperband butterflyfish



Length Up to 8 in (20 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location Indo-Pacific



With their sideways-flattened bodies and long, pincerlike snouts, copperband butterflyfishes are ideally shaped for picking small animals from cracks and crevices in coral reefs. This species has 3 orange bands on its sides, and a narrow black band at the base of its tail. These striking markings, and the prominent black eye-spot on the dorsal fin, help confuse predators. At night, the copperband butterflyfish takes on a blotchy coloration to blend in with the background of the reef.

Oxycirrhites typus

Longnose hawkfish



Length Up to 5 in (13 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Sequential hermaphrodite
Status Least concern

Location Indian Ocean, Pacific



The 35 species of hawkfishes inhabit tropical waters and are found on coral or rocky reefs. Often resting on sea fans and black corals, these lie-and-wait predators ambush small floating and bottom crustaceans. It has whitish and red stripes and spots that form a cross-hatch pattern, and an elongated snout used to pick up prey. This fish is mostly found on its own, but the male is territorial. Males court females and pairs of longnose hawkfish spawn after sunset in the water a short distance above the seabed.

